www.tntextbooks.in

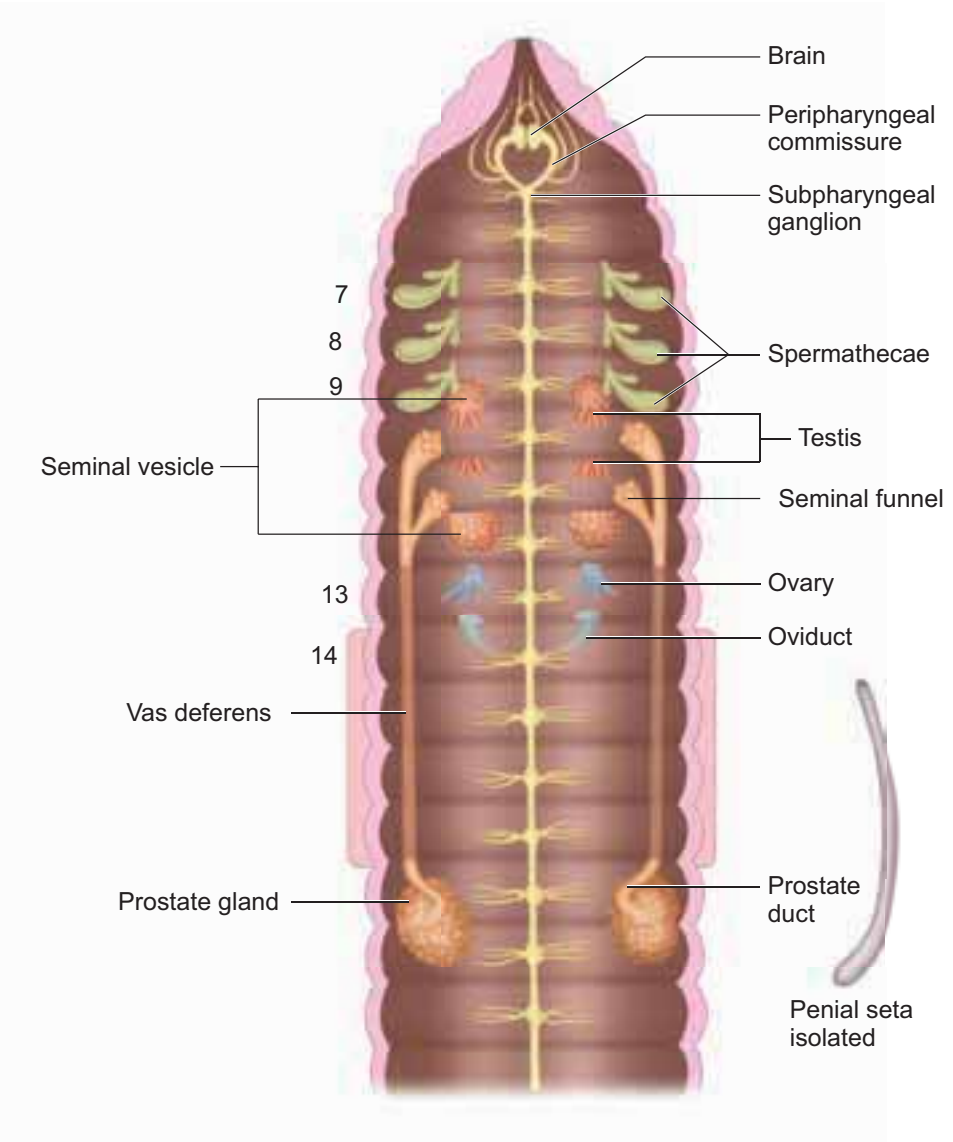


Figure: 4. 6 *Lampito mauritii*: Reproductive System.

Reproductive System

Earthworms are hermaphrodites or monoecious i.e. male and female reproductive organs are found in the same individual (Figure 4. 6). Self fertilization is avoided because two sex organs mature at different times, which means the sperm develops earlier than the production of ova **(Protandrous).** Thus cross fertilization takes place.

In the male reproductive system, two pairs of testes are present in the 10th and 11th segments. The testes give rise to the **germ cells** or **spermatogonia**, which develops into spermatozoa in the two pairs of seminal vesicles. Two pairs of seminal funnels called **ciliary rosettes** are situated in the same segments as the testes. The ciliated funnels of the same side are connected to a long tube called vas deferens. The **vasa deferentia** run upto the 18th segment where they open to the exterior through the **male genital aperture**. The male genital aperture contains two pairs of **penial setae** for copulation. A pair of prostate glands lies in the 18th – 19th segments. The secretion of the prostate gland serves to cement the spermatozoa into bundles known as **spermatophores**.